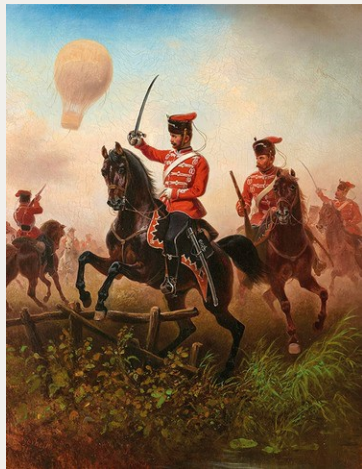


IN CONTEXT

The Franco-Prussian War

Brahms was deeply patriotic and greatly admired the statesman Otto von Bismarck, the driving force behind the creation of a unified Germany. As part of his expansionist policies, Bismarck engineered wars against Denmark (1864), Austria (1866), and France (1870–1871). The last of these, the Franco-Prussian War, humiliated France and established Germany as a major power. Brahms wrote a choral work, *Triumphlied* (Song of Triumph), in celebration.



PRUSSIAN HUSSARS IN THE FRANCO-PRUSSIAN WAR, 1871

Brahms was so brutally self-critical that he destroyed many more of his works than he published. He discarded almost all of his juvenilia and even in middle age—when he became prosperous and famous—he was still known to burn compositions that he considered unsatisfactory.

One result of this refusal to compromise is that Brahms's